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Section Title(S)

LEVELS OF VIOLENCE • TALKING: ARGUMENTS AND VERBAL ABUSE

In approaching this material it is useful to note how disputes escalate from one level to another and to attempt at each stage to determine what factors operate to limit conflict and what factors lead to its heightening.

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TALKING: ARGUMENTS AND VERBAL ABUSE

The San do not fight much, but they do talk a great deal. In fact, they may be among the most talkative people in the world. Much of this talk verges on argument, often for its own sake and usually ad hominem, as ably documented by Lorna Marshall (1961, 1976). Accusations of improper meat distribution, improper gift exchange (*hxaro*), laziness, and stinginess are the most common topics of these disputes. Often they are followed by a group split, as one or both of the principals leaves the camp for a cooling-off period. N!eishin!a and his brother-in-law ≠Toma//gwe at Dobe, for example, have been coalescing and splitting for years. Every year or so one or the other packs up after an argument and takes off with his group, only to recombine the following season.

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The most common kind of argument heard is called *hore hore* or *oba oba*, !Kung words that mean "yakity-yak." It is often punctuated by a joke that

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breaks the tension and leaves the participants rolling on the ground helpless with laughter. Simply because these arguments happen to be funny does not mean that they lack seriousness. They *are* serious, and they proceed along the knife edge between laughter and anger. Indeed, one of the purposes of this kind of argument is to provoke one's opponent to anger so that one can retort with injured innocence: "What's the matter, we were only kidding" (see Lee 1969b).

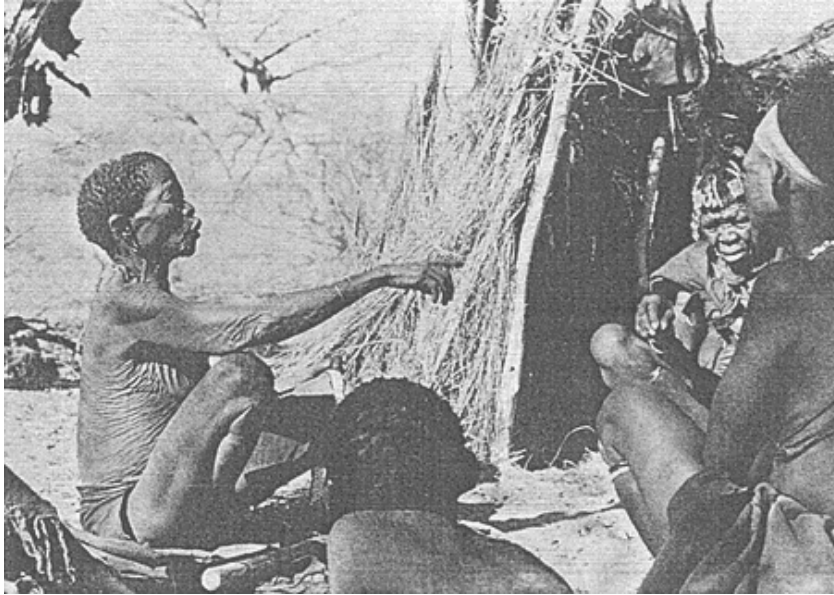
When disputants get really angry (i.e., when both parties drop the pretense of good humor), a talk ensues. The "talk" (*n̄wa*), first described by Marshall (1961:232), is an outpouring of verbal anger with extravagant statements delivered in a stylized staccato form. A good example of the *n̄wa* is John Marshall's film, *An Argument About a Marriage* (1973). Of this level of verbal conflict, the !Kung say that *si !x"asi dui* ("their hearts rise up"). The point of potential danger has been passed, and the combatants are no longer completely in control of the situation. Fighting may break out directly, or the talk may move on to another level: verbal abuse involving sex.

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The third and final phase of conflict on the verbal level is *za* ("sexual insulting"). The *za* mode occupies the ambiguous position of being both the highest form of affectionate joking between appropriate kin in the [373](#)

Plate 13.1. An argument involving women.



"joking relationship" and the deadliest affront leading directly to fighting. The primary *za* form addressed to males is *!ki nu wa n!u* ("may death pull back your foreskin"), a grave insult among a people who do not practice circumcision and among whom the glans penis is exposed only during sexual arousal. For females the most common *za* forms are *!ki du a !gum* ("death on your vagina") and *!gum/twisi#dinyazho* ("long black labia"), the latter a reference to the elongated labia minora characteristic of San and Khoi-Khoi female genitalia. According to the !Kung, to be the recipient of *za* in anger arouses intense feelings of *dokum* ("shame"), leading to suicide or assault.

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